in turn, are ideas over the nitty-gritty of specific policy related programmes. Policy change occurs when advocacy coalitions (like the partisans and the conciliators) with different belief systems and resources interact with each other.[22]

The ACF has much strength for the purpose of this book. Not only does it help in explaining policy change, but it also helps in identifying policy narratives and coalitions. Policy narratives are constructs, strategically crafted using words, images, and symbols to influence policy output.[23] They are ways to structure and communicate one's understanding of the world, and can be applied both in domestic and international policy domains. Any policy narrative, effectively, would 'have a setting, a plot, characters (hero, villain, and victim), and will be disseminated towards a preferred policy outcome (the moral of the story)'.[24] Different advocacy coalitions—such as the partisans and the conciliators—formed by different stakeholders within the policy subsystem, generate different policy narratives. While a 'winners' tale seeks status quo, a 'losers' tale demands policy change. Moreover, while a winning advocate would focus on costs associated with change than its accruing benefits, a losing advocate would concentrate on gains over loses. However, regardless of groups portraying themselves as either 'winning' or 'losing', there are some stable policy core beliefs 'shaped by [the] cultural context (social and economic history and view of the role of the government) in which the policy issue occurs'. Resultantly, analysing 'narrative elements of characters can reveal an advocacy coalition's policy beliefs'.[25] These ACF tools help form the analytical bedrock of this book and its argument.

In addition to helping delineate policy advocacy conceptually (not just based on political rhetoric), the ACF provides the 'middle-level' theoretical backbone that explains operational-level policy-making. Neither does it challenge global systemic theories such as realism and liberalism (or constructivism), nor does it go into the minutiae of tactical policy decisions related to a specific incident in India-Afghanistan relations. It allows for providing an operational understanding of how India's foreign policy towards Afghanistan was formulated. Partisans and conciliators, from this perspective, are not card-holding members of any policy organisation. They are not even officials representing the interests of specific institutions. These are individuals or groups who have policy beliefs on a particular foreign policy problem and they cut across India's political,